ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 111: Introduction to Drama and Theatre in the World

The concepts and vocabularies you need before every other theatre course

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This course exists to stop you using 'drama', 'theatre', 'performance' and 'play' as if they mean the same thing. The pack sets out the working distinctions, traces the move from ritual to built theatres, and gives you a vocabulary for discussing any performance tradition in the world.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Distinguish drama as text from theatre as performance event.
- Trace the shift from ritual and festival performance to purpose-built theatre buildings.
- Identify the social conventions that shape performance in different periods.
- Use genre and structural terms accurately in written answers.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Four terms that are not synonyms

Precise vocabulary earns marks and prevents confused essays.

- Drama: the written or composed work, its structure, character and dialogue.
- Theatre: the collaborative event, including performers, space, audience and technology.
- Performance: the broader category of staged human action, including dance and ritual.
- Play: usually a dramatic text; a production is one realisation of it.
- Text and production can differ sharply: a director's choices are an interpretation, not a copy.

From ritual to theatre house

The institution of theatre grew out of communal performance and accumulated its own conventions.

- Greek festival theatre: civic competition, masks, chorus and open-air amphitheatre.
- Roman spectacle: larger structures, entertainment politics and a shift in audience composition.
- Medieval religious drama: pageant wagons, guild cycles and church calendar.
- Asian traditions: Noh, Kabuki and Sanskrit theatre developed their own conventions rather than following Europe.
- African festival theatre retained participatory structures that European proscenium theatre reduced.
- Each built form encodes a social relation between performer and audience.

> **The proscenium is an argument**
> A proscenium arch separates performers from spectators. That separation is a historical choice, not a neutral default, and it changes what performance can do.

Talking about structure and genre

Use these terms with a definition and an example.

- Plot, character, thought, diction, song and spectacle: Aristotle's six elements, still useful as an analysis checklist.
- Tragedy, comedy, tragicomedy, farce, satire and melodrama: know the conventions that define each.
- Conflict, complication, climax and resolution: describe structure rather than retelling plot.
- Dramatic irony: the audience knows what a character does not.
- Convention: an agreed shorthand the audience accepts, from soliloquy to puppetry.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 111

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 111 Introduction to Drama and Theatre in the World described as an introduction to the nature of drama and theatre
- Emphasis on non-written traditions, festivals and rituals up to the institution of built stages and arenas
- Attention to the social conventions operating in those venues that create both literature and performance

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 111 Introduction to Drama and Theatre in the World, 3 credits, first semester
- Listed beside THA 101, 131, 151, 153 and 161 in the same semester
- Total first-semester load shown as 24 credits including GST courses

What changed: The 2019 listing keeps THA 111 as a core 100-level first-semester course with no title change.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- THA 111 remains the conceptual gateway to the programme in the compiled 2025/2026 map
- Expect comparative examples from African, Asian and European traditions rather than a Europe-only survey
- Confirm the current credit value, since 100-level loads were revised in later listings

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Distinguish drama from theatre in one sentence each.

Answer: Drama is the composed work with its structure and dialogue; theatre is the live collaborative event that stages it before an audience.

2. Why is the proscenium arch historically significant?

Answer: It institutionalised a clear separation between performers and audience, shaping realistic illusion and a passive spectator role.

3. What does dramatic irony require?

Answer: A gap between what the audience knows and what a character knows, used to create tension or humour.

4. Name Aristotle's six elements of drama.

Answer: Plot, character, thought, diction, song and spectacle.

5. Give one example of a theatrical convention and explain what it asks the audience to accept.

Answer: The soliloquy asks the audience to accept that a character is speaking their private thoughts aloud while others on stage do not hear.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write definitions of drama, theatre, performance and play.
- [ ] Draw a timeline from Greek festival theatre to the modern stage.
- [ ] Compare two world theatre traditions in a table of conventions.
- [ ] Analyse a short play using Aristotle's six elements.
- [ ] Collect five theatrical conventions with one example each.
- [ ] Write a 250-word answer distinguishing text from production.
- [ ] Learn ten genre terms and match each to a play you know.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | Theatre & Film Studies | 100L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: